

Preparation of Research Report

Research Report

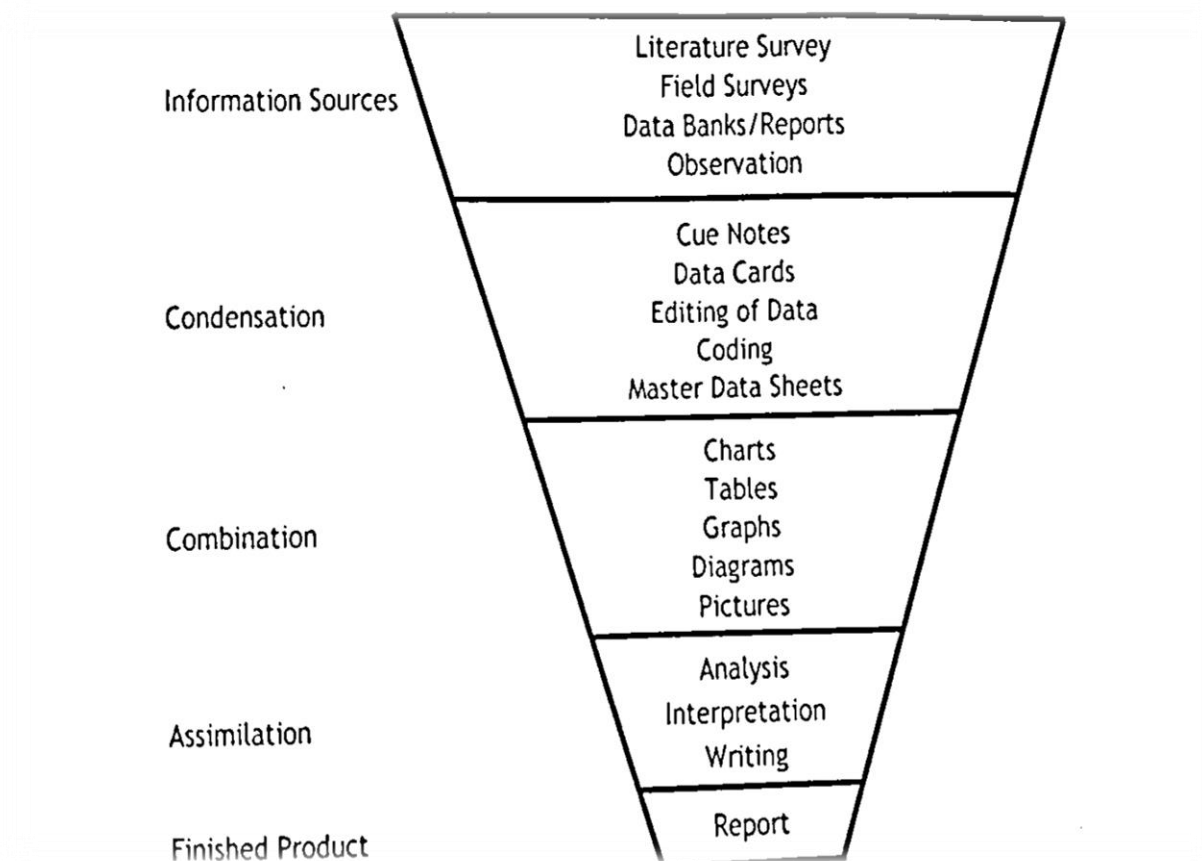
A report is simply a statement or description of things that have already occurred. It is concise, clear communication of the important findings of the research work. Reports communicate information which has been compiled as a result of research and analysis of data and of issues. Reports focus on transmitting information with a clear purpose, to a specific audience. Good reports are documents that are accurate, objective and complete. They should be well-written, clearly structured and expressed in a way that holds the reader's attention and meets their expectations.

Purpose and Importance of Research Reports

- It is a means whereby the data, analysis and conclusions are placed in an organized form. These information can be used both for academic and application purposes.
- Your research work will be judged mainly by the quality of the report. The examining committee may not see your effort while at field. Your research report is the "only tangible product" of hundreds of hours of work. Therefore, you should show your performance, skills, and thoughts in your report, as these are vital to its assessment and grading.
- The effectiveness of the report may be judged by its use. The organizations, professors, researchers and students are using good reports for different purposes. Report writing may benefit you in any of the following ways, although the relative importance of each will change as the program of work progresses:
 - To see whether you are on target with your work, so that any problems can be spotted in time to be attended to.
 - To provide an opportunity for you to reflect on progress, consolidate arguments and identify any gaps in knowledge, data or methodology.
 - To help you to develop an appreciation of standards and hence to learn to monitor your own progress.
 - To provide practice in academic report writing and academic discourse, so that any additional training which may be necessary in this report can be supplied at an early stage.
 - To form a basis, in due course, for your project work and possibly a journal article.

Research Report Process

There are five steps in the research reporting process. At the top, we have raw data collected from different sources. The data is then passed through different stages of compression. Given figure highlights this report process.



Types of Research Reports

i) Descriptive Reports

Descriptive reports are description of facts, trends or opinions gathered by you in course of your investigation. The presentation and analysis of facts in an organized way may be of real value in properly understanding the situation. These reports indicate the current situation and the nature of the problems facing the organization under study and also indicate the reforms required to overcome the problems.

(ii) Analytical Reports

Analytical reports go one step further than descriptive reports. These reports, in addition to presenting facts and statistics, interpret this information in relation to the problem under consideration. Focused on a single or limited area of the problem, these reports follow the process of scientific investigation and reporting. These reports also recommend the actions to be taken for improvements in the situation. You may choose any one of these types of reports. The choice of the types would depend on the nature of your investigation..

Procedures for Report Writing

There are no set rules for writing a research report. A procedure that works well for one person may not work so well for another.

Analyze the Task

You may find the following questions useful when analyzing the task:

- I. What is the purpose of the report?
- II. What should I look up?
- III. Who will read my report?
- IV. What is the word limit?
- V. What is the expected format of the report?

Prepare Outline

In view of your task analysis and the data that you have collected, you can draw an outline of reporting prior to actually starting the write up. An outline is a roadmap to keep you from getting lost when you start to write. This will help you in arranging ideas in a better way. This will also enable you to see broadly which information you want to communicate and how the various points are related to one another. Thus, for effective report writing, it is essential to plan its contents well.

Plan Your Time

The campus/college decides the date of report submission. Therefore, you may not have enough time to work at ease. As you have to meet the time schedule, it is always better for you to plan the available time accordingly. Delays in submission of the research report may cause problems for the student as well as the campus/college.

Arrange Data

You may have collected the data from different sources. The raw data need to be processed and tabulated first. After some editing work is done, the data would be somewhat revealing. You then have to arrange the data in some sequential order for meaningful presentation. The better you organize and arrange the data, the better the data will be revealing.

Start Writing

In writing, the beginning is often difficult. You may begin with the introduction and proceed through to the conclusion. But it is always better to start writing the sections, which appear to be especially easy. This would increase the enthusiasm for the task and enhance your level of confidence.

Prepare the First Draft

You should never expect to produce the excellent report in the first attempt. This may not even be possible for experienced writers. Therefore, it is better to prepare the draft first. Then you can rewrite where necessary.

Put the Report aside for a Day or Two

After preparing the first draft, you can keep the report aside for a day or two and can do some other work. Forgetting about the report for a day or two can be very beneficial. Then you review the report afresh, almost as objectively as another person. If you find weaknesses, you can remove or correct them.

Review and Rewrite

In any report, there is always some scope for improvement. You must review your work in terms of the format and style of reporting. You must ensure that you have followed the format and style prescribed by your campus/college. You should also review your work to identify any errors in grammar, spelling, punctuation, sentence structure, etc. Revision or editing is not the same as re-writing the whole thing from scratch. What you are doing is taking a close and careful look at each word, sentence, and paragraph to make sure you have made the best choices.

Style of Report Writing

Write Clearly

The sentence must be as simple as possible. Two or three relatively simple sentences may convey an idea more clearly than one complicated sentence. Similarly, you should not write long paragraphs. You should divide the material into separate paragraphs and use sub-headings, if necessary, to highlight important separate points. The words used must express precisely what you want to say. Finally, you must make sure that the report has uniform style and format.

Adhere to the Study Objectives

You should focus on the research problem. The main purpose of the research investigation is to answer the questions that derive from the statement of objectives. The findings or a simple piece of writing without reference to the objective may be a futile exercise.

Be Careful of Terminology, Grammar and Spelling

The fundamental medium of communicating one's findings is words. Therefore, you should give adequate attention to the correct use of grammar and to the correct spellings of all word. Similarly, appropriate punctuation marks must also be used according to the standard rules and not arbitrarily.

Be Selective

Research reports cannot include everything known on the given subject. If an attempt is made to include too much, there is always danger that the important points will be lost in the detail. Unnecessary accumulation of materials may distort the focus. Hence, you should make good judgment as to what materials to include in the report and what to exclude.

Be Objective

Objectivity is an important determinant of the quality of a research report. Hence, objectivity should be maintained in your research methods and interpretations. You must at all times retain your objectivity. In other words, facts should determine conclusions. Objectivity is essential because it is necessary that others be able to understand and replicate a finding before it is considered dependable. Hence, extra caution should be taken to keep the research reporting process bias-free.

Draw Conclusions

Students often confuse conclusions with research findings. Findings state facts. Conclusions represent inferences drawn from the findings. Findings are just like threads in a handloom. These threads need to be woven, intermixed and converted into a finished product called conclusion..